Princess Tarhata Alonto Lucman

Princess Tarhata Alonto-Lucman (June 26, 1926 -- February 26, 2021), widely called ***Babo a Tatah*** (Aunt Tarhata) across Lanao, was a Maranao princess, politician, and peacebuilder who became the first female governor of Lanao del Sur.

She was born into one of the most prominent political dynasties in the history of Muslim Mindanao, and she spent nearly a century using that position to champion governance reform, women's dignity, and communal peace.

Her life cut a path that very few women of her generation anywhere in the Philippines could claim: she challenged patriarchal tradition as a child, broke the gender ceiling of provincial governance as an adult, stood firm against a dictatorship at great personal cost, organized resistance from exile, and then came home to negotiate the release of hostages without firing a single shot.

Both the Senate of the Philippines and the Bangsamoro Parliament formally honored her memory after her death in 2021.

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ROYAL LINEAGE AND FAMILY

Tarhata was born on June 26, 1926, in Ramain, Lanao, into the absolute summit of Maranao royalty.

Princess Tarhata Alonto-Lucman



Personal Information

Born: June 26, 1926
Ramain, Lanao, Philippines

Died: February 26, 2021 (aged 94)
Amai Pakpak Medical Center, Marawi City, Philippines

Royal Title

Princess of Ramain; daughter of Sultan Alauya Alonto

Spouse

Sultan Haroun Rashid Lucman, Paramount Sultan of Bayang (deceased 1984)

Children

Includes former Lanao del Sur Vice Governor Normalah Alonto Lucman

Political Office

Governor of Lanao del Sur (elected 1971; removed 1975 under Martial Law)
Officer-in-Charge Governor of Lanao del Sur (appointed 1986; served until 1988)

Political Affiliation

Template:Fact

Religion

Islam (Sunni)

Her father was **Sultan Alauya Alonto** of Ramain, a historic statesman who served as the very **first Muslim senator of the Philippines**. Growing up in his household meant that statecraft, Islamic theology, and the traditional customary law known as adat were simply part of daily life.

Leadership ran deep through the whole Alonto clan across multiple generations.

Her brother **Senator Domocao Alonto** followed their father's path into Philippine national politics, and he became one of the chief architects of modern Islamic institutions in the country, helping establish Mindanao State University and the Philippine Amanah Bank.

Another brother, **Governor Abdulgafor Madki Alonto**, served as Governor of Lanao del Sur from 1959 to 1967 and later represented the Philippines as a diplomatic **ambassador**, with his administration serving as a critical political anchor for the province during a particularly transitional decade.

The family legacy carried into the next generation as well. **Datu Abul Khayr D. Alonto**, the son of Governor Madki Alonto and Tarhata's nephew, abandoned his law studies at San Beda during the onset of Martial Law and joined the Moro National Liberation Front (MNLF) as one of its founding **"Top 90"** cadres, eventually becoming its **Vice Chairman**. He later transitioned into civilian public service as Chairman of the Mindanao Development Authority (MinDA), a post he held until his passing in 2019.

Ethnicity

Maranao

Known Titles

"Iron Lady of Lanao"; *Babo a Tatah* (Aunt Tarhata)

Notability

Maranao royalty and pioneering politician from Lanao del Sur; first female Governor of Lanao del Sur; peacebuilder and anti-Marcos dissident; humanitarian in exile; negotiated the 1986 Marawi hostage crisis without military force

Known For

Breaking gender barriers in Maranao politics; defying Martial Law; organizing the Bangsa Moro exile resistance in Saudi Arabia; personally negotiating the unconditional release of kidnapped Carmelite nuns and foreign missionaries in 1986; refusing her own government salary and redirecting it to low-income provincial employees

Tarhata's own marriage brought another layer to this convergence of royal and political power. She chose **Sultan Haroun Rashid Lucman**, the Paramount Sultan of Bayang and a prominent congressional representative, as her husband. Together they became something close to the definitive power couple of Lanao, blending centuries of royal prestige with the practical authority of modern democratic politics.

This lineage did not merely grant her privilege. It handed her a sense of duty she took seriously for the rest of her life. Her children carried that tradition forward, including former Lanao del Sur Vice Governor Normalah Alonto Lucman.

EARLY LIFE AND EDUCATION

Growing up in an era when Maranao customs confined noblewomen firmly to domestic life, Tarhata began defying expectations almost from the moment she was old enough to remember anything.

When she was five years old, she survived a life-threatening illness after being treated at a Christian-run hospital. At the time, traditionalists considered this a radical and deeply uncomfortable step, fearing it would open the door to conversion.

She then defied convention again by pursuing a formal education. She was tutored by American Thomasites, including an adoptive mentor she called Mrs. Spencer. Tarhata proved to be a child prodigy: when she entered the public school system, her sharp intellect let her skip several grade levels, landing in Grade 4 at just six years old.

As a young girl, she traveled frequently to Manila to serve as an English-language translator and aide for her senator father, absorbing the rhythms of national politics before most children her age had left their hometown.

She dreamed of eventually studying law. But traditional expectations finally caught up with her in Grade 7, when a dominant maternal uncle decided she had already received more than enough schooling for a woman of her standing and ordered her to withdraw from formal studies. She obeyed, but she did not stop learning, and she did not stop pushing.

Years later, she exercised a rare form of personal autonomy for her time and social position by choosing her own husband, quietly subverting the marital traditions of her era on her own terms.

POLITICAL CAREER

Election and Governance Reforms

In 1971, Tarhata Alonto-Lucman won the election for Governor of Lanao del Sur, shattering what had been an exclusively male political space.

She did not treat the governorship as ceremonial. Her administration moved quickly to institutionalize performance-based budgeting across the provincial government, effectively ending the long-entrenched practice where officials took personal cuts or commissions before public funds ever reached their intended recipients.

She championed regional agricultural modernization under national development programs and launched aggressive reforestation campaigns to protect the local environment.

She also made a personal decision that became one of the most quietly striking symbols of her tenure: she refused to keep her official government salary, directing the provincial treasury to distribute her entire paycheck among the lowest-income employees at the Capitol instead.

Defiance of Martial Law

Her most defining political test arrived in September 1972, when President Ferdinand Marcos Sr. declared Martial Law across the Philippines.

While many local officials quietly aligned themselves with the Marcos administration out of fear or political calculation, Governor Alonto-Lucman did not. She openly criticized the dictatorship, provided protection to dissenters, and quietly backed the growing Moro youth resistance that was fighting for self-determination.

Her defiance infuriated Malacañang Palace. In 1975, the Marcos regime stripped her of her governorship.

Restoration Under the Aquino Administration

Following the 1986 People Power Revolution that ended the Marcos dictatorship, President Corazon Aquino appointed Tarhata as Officer-in-Charge (OIC) Governor of Lanao del Sur, recognizing her integrity and restoring her to the helm of her province. She served in that capacity until 1988.

THE SAUDI ARABIA EXILE

After her removal from office in 1975, Tarhata and her husband Sultan Haroun Rashid Lucman fled to Saudi Arabia, settling in Riyadh and Jeddah.

For over a decade, their home in exile functioned as far more than a private residence. It became a strategic hub, a safe house, a diplomatic back-channel, and a welfare center for thousands of Filipinos who had nowhere else to turn.

Sultan Rashid Lucman organized and chaired the Bangsa Moro Liberation Organization (BMLO) during this period. Tarhata served as its organizational matriarch, coordinating political networks and smoothing over the volatile ideological rifts that naturally emerged among exiled Moro leaders, youth activists, and traditional royalty trying to sustain a resistance movement from thousands of miles away.

The couple used their royal lineage to secure direct access to the Saudi royal family and the Organization of Islamic Cooperation (OIC), through which they successfully drew international attention to the human rights situation in Mindanao under Martial Law.

Their home also served as what might best be described as an underground railroad. Thousands of Filipino Muslims fleeing military violence in Mindanao, along with political dissidents escaping imprisonment in Manila, arrived in Saudi Arabia with essentially nothing. Tarhata personally managed a vast informal welfare network from her home, providing food, shelter, documentation assistance, and help finding legitimate employment within the Kingdom.

The exile years also created an unexpected but historically significant bridge. When mainstream opposition figures from Manila, including Ninoy Aquino and Jovito Salonga, traveled to the Middle East seeking international support for the anti-Marcos movement, the Lucman home in Saudi Arabia became the meeting point where the Moro struggle and the democratic resistance in Manila found common ground.

Sultan Rashid Lucman passed away in Saudi Arabia in 1984 and was buried in the royal burial grounds of the Kingdom.

Tarhata carried the mantle alone for the final two years of exile, keeping the resistance network operational until the 1986 EDSA Revolution finally allowed her to bring their work home.

THE 1986 MARAWI HOSTAGE CRISIS

In July 1986, just months after People Power had restored democratic governance, a massive hostage crisis erupted in Lanao del Sur.

A heavily armed group of rogue rebels, often referred to as a "lost command," kidnapped ten Filipino Carmelite nuns from their hilltop convent in Marawi City. The kidnappers also seized Fr. Michel de Gigord, a French Catholic chaplain serving at Mindanao State University, and Brian Lawrence, an American Protestant missionary.

The newly installed Aquino government faced a nightmare calculation: a military rescue operation carried the real risk of triggering an all-out religious conflict in Mindanao.

Princess Tarhata, recently returned from exile and serving as OIC Governor, stepped directly into the vacuum.

Rather than deploying troops or provincial police, she used what she considered her most effective weapon: the traditional code of maratabat (royal honor) and her standing as Babo a Tatah.

She explicitly ordered the Armed Forces of the Philippines to stand down, knowing that a military presence would only escalate the danger. She then walked directly into the remote rural area where the captors were holding the hostages, accompanied only by a small, trusted group of clan elders.

Once inside, she confronted the captors directly. Drawing on her authority as a Maranao princess and the daughter of Sultan Alauya Alonto, she shamed them for violating ancestral Maranao codes of chivalry and Islamic teachings that strictly forbid the harming of women, travelers, and religious figures.

Her moral authority proved more effective than any armed intervention could have been. She secured the safe, unconditional release of all ten Carmelite nuns and both foreign missionaries without a single casualty, without a ransom payment, and without a shot fired.

LEGACY AS PEACEBUILDER

Long after her formal political career ended, Tarhata remained the spiritual and moral center of Lanao.

She earned the title "**Iron Lady of Lanao**" not just for her record of political courage, but for her persistent and uncompromising work on peace and communal harmony. In Mindanao, rido (inter-clan feud) is a persistent cycle where retaliatory violence can stretch across generations. Armed with little more than her royal authority and the deep personal trust communities placed in her, Babo a Tatah regularly entered active conflict zones to negotiate peace pacts between warring families.

She supported weapons turn-in initiatives to reduce the circulation of firearms in the province. She frequently depleted her personal family savings to fund the pilgrimage fares of former rebels traveling to Mecca or Medina as part of their community rehabilitation.

Her approach to peace was rooted in a holistic sense of social justice. She understood that lasting peace required more than the silencing of guns; it required people to have reasons to choose peace, and she worked to provide those reasons.

CULTURAL SIGNIFICANCE

Tarhata Alonto-Lucman served as a living bridge between ancestral Maranao royalty and modern democratic governance.

She made a deliberate, consistent choice to resist the westernization of public life. At high-profile state dinners, diplomatic functions, and international events, she wore the traditional Maranao malong, treating it not as a costume but as a statement about who she was and what she represented.

By occupying the highest echelons of public power in her province while remaining visibly, unapologetically Maranao, she permanently shifted the socio-cultural landscape of Mindanao.

Her life made a practical argument that conservative families across the region could not easily dismiss: that educating daughters would strengthen and preserve Maranao society rather than dilute it.

DEATH AND HONORS

Princess Tarhata Alonto-Lucman passed away from a heart attack on February 26, 2021, at the age of 94, at the Amai Pakpak Medical Center in Marawi City.

Following her passing, both the Senate of the Philippines and the Bangsamoro Parliament passed official resolutions honoring her life and legacy, cementing her standing as an enduring icon of peace, good governance, and Bangsamoro women's leadership.

SEE ALSO

- Lanao del Sur
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM)
- Moro National Liberation Front (MNLF)
- Bangsa Moro Liberation Organization (BMLO)
- Mindanao State University
- Domocao Alonto
- Haroun Rashid Lucman
- Normalah Alonto Lucman
- Abul Khayr D. Alonto
- Maratabat
- Rido

REFERENCES

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1. Source biography submitted to BangsamoroPedia: https://tinyurl.com/4w8dwrpe

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